

**THE THIRD EDITION OF** the Bihar Museum Biennale (BMB), taking place from August 7 to December 31, marks a bold and timely moment in the international cultural calendar. Conceived in 2021 as the world's first biennale dedicated exclusively to museums, BMB has grown rapidly into a global platform for cultural dialogue, institutional exchange and curatorial innovation.

Its founder and director general of the Bihar Museum, Anjani Kumar Singh, recalls how the idea was born. "When we built the Bihar Museum and began visiting major museums and art biennales worldwide, I noticed there was no dedicated platform for museums and art institutions to share their exhibitions, histories and practices, or to discuss common challenges."

The BMB's first edition launched virtually during the pandemic, opening the door to international participation from the outset. By 2023, as India hosted the G20 presidency, the second edition featured museums from over 15 countries and welcomed the G20 Art Exhibition *Together We Art*. These early editions helped establish Bihar as a rising force in global museology. The 2025 edition only deepens this ambition.

This year's biennale turns its focus to the Global South: Asia, Africa and Latin America. Institutions from countries including Indonesia, Sri Lanka, Kazakhstan, Ethiopia, Mexico, Argentina, Ecuador and Peru will take part. Each has been given curatorial freedom to present its collections and ideas in a way that reflects its own cultural priorities.

"When I visited countries in Africa and Latin America, I was struck by their richness in art, history and culture—and by how little of it is known in India," Singh reflects. "This edition removes thematic constraints, allowing museums to bring what best represents them. As a result, we're seeing connections emerge organically—through shared stories, iconographies and ideas."

Long a crossroads of ancient trade, culture and learning, Bihar now positions itself at the centre of a new conversation between post-colonial nations. The biennale invites these countries not only to display their heritage, but to reimagine what a museum can be in the 21st century.

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The 2025 edition embraces a more experiential model of exhibition-making. Highlights include a collaborative mask exhibition featuring pieces from the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA), the Patna Museum, and artists Seema Kohli and Sachindranath Jha, exploring the global symbolism of masks in ritual and performance. The National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA), New Delhi, contributes a powerful painting exhibition centred on the shared histories of the Global South.

The biennale has a long-term goal: strengthening museum-to-museum partnerships, especially within the Global South. Singh points out that, historically, few Indian exhibitions have travelled abroad, and most global museums have been reluctant to bring their collections to India, primarily due to infrastructure and conservation standards. That's changing.